

GALLANT IAS ACADEMY
PRELIMS CUM MAINS BATCH 2027
ANCIENT INDIA
MODULE 6

MAHAJANAPADAS & FOREIGN INVASIONS

The 6th century BCE was a major turning point in early Indian history. It saw the emergence of early states and cities, increasing use of iron, development of coinage, and the rise of Buddhism and Jainism. Early Buddhist and Jaina texts refer to sixteen major states called Mahajanapadas. Important examples include Magadha, Vajji, Kosala, Kuru, Panchala, Gandhara and Avanti.

Main features

- Mahajanapadas developed out of earlier Janapadas or territorial settlements.
- Most Mahajanapadas were ruled by kings.
- Some, such as Vajji, were ganas or sanghas.
- ganas/sanghas as oligarchies, where political power was shared by a number of men who were often collectively called rajas.
- Both Buddha and Mahavira belonged to such gana-sangha backgrounds.
- In some ganas, such as Vajji, ruling groups probably exercised collective control over resources such as land.

Capitals and fortification

Each Mahajanapada generally had a capital city, and many capitals were fortified with walls of wood, brick or stone.

Forts served several purposes:

- protection from attacks,
- demonstration of the ruler's wealth and power,
- easier control over people and territory.

Construction and maintenance of fortified cities required considerable labour and resources.

Administration and army

Rulers of Mahajanapadas began maintaining more organised armies. Soldiers could be maintained throughout the year, and some payments were probably made through punch-marked coins. Fortified cities, armies and emerging bureaucracies required regular resources and therefore encouraged systematic taxation.

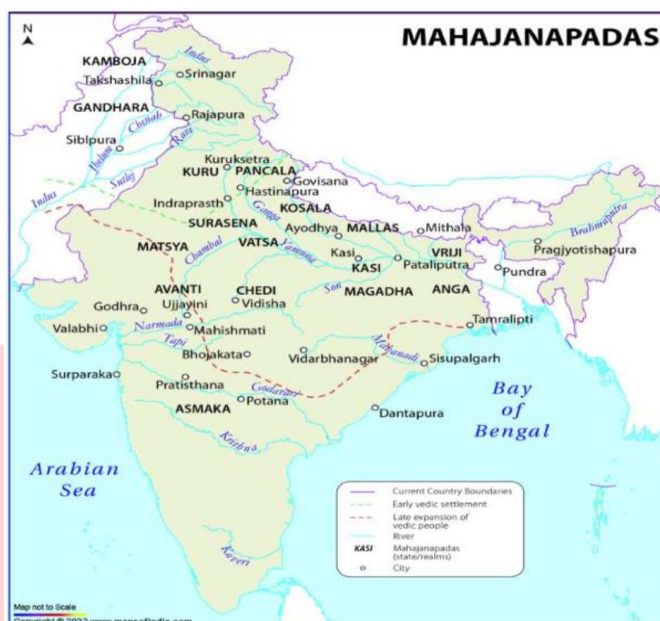
Mahajanapadas literally means 'greater territorial states'. In the later Vedic period, tribal organisations changed their identity and gradually shifted to a territorial identity, and the areas of settlement were now regarded as **Janapadas** or states. In the transition from tribe to monarchy and gana sanghas, they lost the essential democratic pattern of the tribe but retained the idea of government through an assembly representing the tribes.

The rise of Janapadas is mainly attributed to the **establishment of settled agricultural communities**. The development of an agriculture-based economy led to an increase in crops and cattle wealth, coupled with the use of iron in technology. Later, each Janapada tried to dominate and subjugate other Janapadas to become **Mahajanapadas**.

IMPORTANT KINGDOMS

The kings in **monarchical states** had supreme authority. The Mahajanapadas of **Vriji, Malla, Kuru, Panchal and Kamboj** were Sangha/Gana states; so were other smaller states like **Lichhavi, Shakya, Koliya, Bhagga, and Moriya**. These states had a **Gana-Parishad** or Assembly of senior and responsible citizens, which held supreme authority. All administrative decisions were taken by this Parishad.

The republics were basically of two types: (a) republics comprising a **single tribe** like those of the Sakyas, the Koliyas and the Mallas; and (b) republics comprising a **number of tribes** (confederacy), like the Vrijjis.



Gana-Sanghas vs Monarchies

Feature	Gana-Sanghas (Republics)	Monarchies
Office Succession	The office was not hereditary.	Hereditary; all powers vested with the king and his family.
Location	Located in or near the Himalayan foothills in eastern India.	The majority occupied the fertile alluvial tracts of the Ganga valley.
Government Form	Representative form of government. The council discussed issues in a hall called Santhagara. Salakas (pieces of wood) used for voting; Salaka-Gahapaka (collector of votes) ensured honesty.	Political power concentrated in the king, assisted by ministers and advisory councils (Parishad and Sabha). With the emergence of the concept of the divinity of kings, popular assemblies declined.
Revenue	Every tribal oligarch claimed share in revenues from peasants.	King claimed to be the sole recipient of such revenues.
Army	Each raja (tribal oligarch) was free to maintain his own army under his senapati.	King maintained a regular standing army and did not permit any other armed forces within his boundaries.
Leadership	Functioned under oligarchic assemblies.	Functioned under individual leadership of the king.
Brahmanical Influence	Brahmanas relegated to the background.	Brahmanas had considerable influence on administration.

The **Ganasanghas** were oligarchies where the king was elected and ruled with the help of a council. **Vajji** was an important Mahajanapada with a Sangha form of government. The founders of both **Jainism and Buddhism** came from republican states. Mahajanapada had a capital city. Most had forts built around them for protection, maintained regular armies, and collected taxes from the people. Usually, the tax on crops was **1/6th of the produce**.

RISE OF MAGADHA

Between the 6th and 4th centuries BCE, **Magadha** (in present-day Bihar) became the most powerful Mahajanapada.

The Haryanka Dynasty

Ruler	Key Contributions
Bimbisara (544-492 BC)	Founder of Magadha's power. Strengthened position through three strategic marriage alliances: (1) daughter of Kosala king/sister of Prasenajit; (2) Chellana, a Lichchhavi Princess from Vaishali; (3) daughter of chief of Madra clan of Punjab. Capital at Rajgir (Girivraja), surrounded by five hills with stone walls.
Ajatasatru (492-460 BC)	Son of Bimbisara; killed his father and seized the throne. Pursued an aggressive policy of expansion throughout his reign.
Udayin (460-444 BC)	Son of Ajatasatru. Built the fort at the confluence of the Ganga and Son at Patna. The location was chosen as it lay at the centre of the Magadhan kingdom.

The Sisunagas

Udayin was succeeded by the **Sisunaga dynasty**, who temporarily shifted the capital to Vaishali. Their greatest achievement was the **destruction of the power of Avanti** with its capital at Ujjain. This brought to an end the **100-year-old rivalry** between Magadha and Avanti.

The Nandas (343-321 BC)

The Sisunagas were succeeded by the **Nandas**, the most powerful rulers of Magadha. Their power was so great that Alexander, who invaded Punjab, **did not dare to move towards the east**. The Nandas added to Magadhan power by conquering Kalinga from where they brought an image of the Jina as a victory trophy - all during the reign of **Mahapadma Nanda**, who claimed to be the **ekarat** (the sole sovereign who destroyed all other ruling princes). The last Nanda ruler was defeated by **Chandragupta Maurya**, who founded the Maurya Empire.

Causes for the Rise of Magadha

Cause	Detail
Ambitious Rulers	Rulers like Bimbisara, Ajatasatru and Mahapadma Nanda pursued aggressive expansion policies.
Geographical Advantage	Both Rajgir and Pataliputra were situated at

	strategic locations.
Natural Resources	Abundance of iron enabled Magadhan rulers to equip armies with effective weapons.
Agricultural Surplus	Alluvial soil of the Gangetic plains and sufficient rainfall enabled surplus agricultural production.
Trade and Commerce	Rise of towns and use of metallic money boosted trade. Rulers could levy tolls, accumulate wealth and maintain armies.
Use of Elephants	Large-scale use of war elephants, aided by proximity to ancient Kalinga.
Unorthodox Society	The unorthodox character of Magadhan society allowed greater flexibility and innovation compared to more rigid Brahmanical societies.

SOCIO-ECONOMIC CONDITIONS DURING MAHAJANAPADAS

Besides the establishment of big empires, another important feature of the age was **increased prosperity and growth of towns**. The primary reason was the growth of foreign trade with the countries of the North-West, Western countries and several countries of Asia.

Several trade routes connected different parts of India. One route ran from **Kosambi** through the Gangetic plain to Punjab and then Taxila, joining routes to Iran, Central Asia and European countries. Another route started from **Rajagriha**, passing through Kosambi and Ujjaini, connecting with the port of **Broach**, from where trade was carried on with western countries by sea. An important route also passed through the entire Gangetic plain to the boundary of Burma.

Towns became centres of both trade and industry. Indian rulers had started **minting coins** in different metals, facilitating transactions and development of trade. The growth of trade and industry formed rich **trading and industrial communities** concentrated in towns.

Evidence proves the existence of different **guilds** formed by traders and industrialists during this period, creating organised and consciously awakened groups in towns - which in turn resulted in the rise of many social sub-classes.

IRANIAN INVASION

The Achaemenian rulers of Iran expanded their empire at the same time as the Magadhan kings, taking advantage of the **political disunity on the north-west frontier**. The Iranian ruler **Darius** penetrated north-west India in **516 BC** and annexed Punjab (west of the Indus) and Sindh. According to Herodotus, Punjab and Sindh satrapy (province) was the **twentieth in the Persian Empire** - the richest and most popular province with an annual tribute amounting to **360 talents of gold-dust**.

The **Kharoshthi script** was used on the north-western frontier from this time until about the 4th century AD. On the eve of Alexander's invasion, the hold of Persian emperors on their Indian provinces had become weak.

Effects of Persian Invasion

Effect	Detail
Introduction of Kharoshthi Script	Kharoshthi script came to be used in the northwest.
Promotion of Indo-Iranian Trade	Opening of trade links between India and Persia.
New Water Route	Geographical exploration of the Indus and the Arabian Sea led to the opening of a new water route.
Fusion in Art	Iranian/Persian features fused into Mauryan art.
Religious Impact	Impact of Buddhism on the Zoroastrian religion of ancient Persia.

ALEXANDER'S INVASION

Alexander III of Macedon defeated the Achaemenid Persian Empire, including Darius III.

- After conquering Persia and Central Asian regions, he moved towards the north-western Indian subcontinent.
- His objective was further territorial expansion and control over regions east of the former Persian Empire.

Course of the Invasion

Entry into north-west India (327 BCE)

- Alexander crossed the Hindu Kush and entered the north-western frontier regions.
- He subdued several local tribes before advancing towards the Indus.

Alliance with Taxila

- Ambhi (Omphis/Taxiles), ruler of Taxila, accepted Alexander's authority and assisted him.
- Ambhi was a rival of Porus (Puru), whose kingdom lay between the Jhelum and Chenab rivers.

Battle of the Hydaspes (326 BCE)

- Alexander fought Porus on the banks of the Hydaspes (Jhelum).
- Porus used a large force including war elephants.
- Alexander won after a difficult battle.
- Impressed by Porus, Alexander restored his kingdom and enlarged his territory, allowing him to rule as a subordinate ally.

Advance to the Beas

- Alexander continued eastwards and reached the Hyphasis (Beas) River.
- His soldiers refused to advance farther.
- They were exhausted after years of campaigning and feared powerful Indian kingdoms further east, particularly the Nanda kingdom of Magadha, which Greek

accounts described as possessing a very large army.

Retreat 326–325 BCE

- Alexander was forced to turn back.
- Part of his army travelled down the Indus.
- He fought several communities, including the Malloi, during which he was seriously wounded.
- He eventually returned westward, while part of the army travelled by sea under Nearchus.
- Alexander died at Babylon in 323 BCE.

Why Alexander Could Not Advance Beyond the Beas

- Exhaustion after nearly eight years of continuous campaigning.
- Strong resistance encountered in north-west India.
- Difficult climate and monsoon conditions.
- Fear of powerful kingdoms east of the Beas.
- Reports of the enormous military resources of the Nandas of Magadha.
- Strong desire among Macedonian soldiers to return home.

Impact of Alexander's Invasion

Political Impact

- Alexander defeated or subordinated several rulers and tribes of north-west India.
- However, his political control was short-lived.
- After his death, Macedonian authority in the region rapidly weakened.
- The political changes in the north-west may have helped create conditions favourable to the subsequent expansion of Chandragupta Maurya, though Alexander's invasion alone cannot be treated as the cause of the Mauryan Empire.

Greater Contact Between India and the Hellenistic World

- The invasion strengthened communication between the Indian subcontinent and regions of West and Central Asia.
- Routes used by armies and traders became better known to the Mediterranean world.

Trade and Communication

- Contacts through the north-western land routes and the Indus–Arabian Sea route increased.
- Nearchus' voyage contributed to Greek knowledge of the sea route between the Indus region and the Persian Gulf.

Historical Importance

- Greek writers recorded valuable information about north-western India.
- Accounts associated with Arrian, Diodorus, Plutarch and Curtius Rufus, although written later and requiring critical evaluation, help reconstruct the political and military conditions of the period.

Military Interaction

- Alexander's army encountered Indian war elephants, infantry and local methods of warfare.

- The campaigns also demonstrated to Indian powers the techniques of Macedonian cavalry and combined military operations.

Cultural Impact

The major development of Greco-Indian cultural interaction, including Gandhara artistic influences and Indo-Greek coinage, occurred mainly later, particularly under the Indo-Greek kingdoms.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTIONS [PRELIMS]

1. The practice of military governorship was first introduced in India by the [2000]

- (a) Greeks (b) Shakas (c) Parthians (d) Mughals

2. Which one of the following dynasties was ruling over North India at the time of Alexander's invasion? [2000]

- (a) Nanda (b) Maurya (c) Sunga (d) Kanva

MODULE PRACTICE QUESTIONS

Q1. Consider the following statements about Mahajanapadas:

1. Anguttara Nikaya is the text which lists the sixteen Mahajanapadas.
2. Bimbisara was the first important ruler of Magadha Mahajanapada.
3. Bimbisara was succeeded by his son Bindusara.
4. The Sisunagas were succeeded by the Nandas.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- (a) 1, 2 and 3 only (b) 2, 3 and 4 only (c) 1, 2 and 4 only (d) 3 and 4 only

Q2. Consider the following statements about Mahajanapadas:

1. The Guilds (Shreni) existed during Mahajanapadas.
2. Anguttara Nikaya, the Buddhist text, knows only 12 Mahajanapadas.
3. Alexander defeated Magadha ruler Mahapadmananda.
4. Chinese pilgrim Fa-hsien visited India during the reign of Kanishka.

Which of the statements given above is/are NOT correct?

- (a) 1, 2 and 3 only (b) 2, 3 and 4 only (c) 1, 2 and 4 only (d) 3 and 4 only

Q3. Magadha Mahajanapada covered:

- (a) Alwar, Bharatpur and Jaipur in Rajasthan
(b) Patna and Gaya in Bihar
(c) Faizabad, Gonda and Bahraich in Uttar Pradesh
(d) Rohilkhand and part of Central Doab in Uttar Pradesh

Q4. Bimbisara, under whom Magadha emerged as a major territorial power in the sixth century BC, belonged to:

- (a) Maurya dynasty (b) Haryanka dynasty (c) Sisunaga dynasty (d) Nanda dynasty

Q5. Which one of the following was a reason for the success of Magadha?

- (a) Affluence of natural resources
(b) Alliance with Greeks
(c) Brahmin hold
(d) Withdrawal of Chandragupta Maurya

Q6. Which of the following were the effects of the Persian invasion on India?

- (a) Introduction of Kharoshthi form of writing
(b) Opening of a new sea route
(c) Promotion of Indo-Iranian trade
(d) All of the above

Q7. Consider the following statements:

1. Mahapadma Nanda was the last ruler of Nanda dynasty who was defeated by

Chandragupta Maurya.

2. Chandragupta Maurya authored Mudrarakshasa which dealt with statecraft and diplomacy.

3. Ashoka who established Dhamma was the son of Chandragupta Maurya.

4. Kautilya's Arthashastra portrays decentralised administration with king as the head.

Which of the statements given above is/are NOT correct?

- (a) 1 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 4 only
- (d) 1, 2, 3 and 4

Q8. Uttaradhyayana was:

- (a) Greek ambassador to the court of Chandragupta Maurya
- (b) Greek trader during Ashoka's time
- (c) Greek trader in the Gupta period
- (d) A Jain Text

Q9. Which one of the following was NOT a reason for the success of Magadha?

- (a) Abundance of natural resources
- (b) Ambitious rulers
- (c) Military superiority
- (d) Decline of Mauryan empire

Q10. Gahapatis during 6th century BC were:

- (a) Merchant guilds
- (b) Peasant proprietors
- (c) Landless farmers
- (d) Moneylenders

GALLANT IAS